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Grant Writing Masterclass

Module 3 — Where Do We Begin?

Student Course Companion

Name: _____ Organization: _____

Team / Cohort (if applicable): _____

This workbook is your hands-on companion to Module 3. Use it during and after the video to reinforce what you learned, apply the concepts to your own organization, and build toward a real grant proposal. If you are working as a team, you will find team discussion prompts throughout each section — look for the green boxes.

Section 1 — Key Terms & Concepts

Review these terms before moving on. They form the foundation of everything covered in this module.

Internal Clarity	A clear, specific understanding of what your organization needs, what it is trying to accomplish, and why it is positioned to do so — developed before any proposal writing begins.
Proactive Grant Seeking	An approach where your organization identifies a program need, defines its goals, and then searches for funders whose priorities align. You drive the narrative.
Request for Proposal (RFP)	An approach where you apply for a specific opportunity a funder has defined. Alignment with the funder's language and requirements is critical. Generic responses rarely succeed.
Common Grant Application	A standardized proposal format accepted by many foundations. Typically includes a cover letter, organization summary, three-page narrative, and attachments.
Cover Letter	The first page of your proposal. Introduces your organization, states the specific ask, and leads with a compelling hook — a

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Organization Summary	story, statistic, or thank-you. Signed by Board Chair and Executive Director.
	Your credibility page. Establishes who you are, how long you have been operating, who you serve, and what you have accomplished. Short but high-stakes.
Three-Page Narrative	The heart of the Common Grant Application. Defines the problem with data, describes your plan and timeline, states measurable outcomes, and addresses sustainability.
Attachments	Supporting documents that verify your narrative — audited financials, operating budget, board list, IRS determination letter, letters of support. Not an afterthought.
The Through-Line	The principle that every section of your proposal must tell one unified, consistent story. Inconsistency between sections erodes funder confidence.
Sustainability Plan	Your description of how the program will continue after the grant period ends — through other funders, earned revenue, or community partnerships.
Measurable Outcome	A specific, data-driven statement of what success looks like. Not “we will help youth” but “85% of participants will improve reading scores by one grade level within 10 months.”
Program Officer	The funder’s staff contact who manages the grant program. Building a relationship with this person before submitting strengthens your proposal.

Section 2 — Annotated Example

Read the annotated Common Grant Application excerpt below. The right column explains what each section is doing and why it works. As you read, think about how you would draft a parallel version for your own organization.

Sample: Common Grant Application — Opening Narrative

PROPOSAL TEXT	WHY IT WORKS
[COVER LETTER OPENING]	→ Opens with a real participant story

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When Marcus was 14, he had already been suspended three times and was reading at a fourth-grade level. Today, at 19, he is a first-generation college student studying engineering. The Bridge Academy made that possible — and your investment will make it possible for 120 more young people just like him this year.	→ Specific details (age, grade level, outcome) make it credible → Connects the funder's investment directly to future impact before the ask is even made
[ORGANIZATION SUMMARY] Founded in 2009, The Bridge Academy has served 4,800 youth across seven Title I schools in the metro area. In our most recent program year, 91% of participants advanced at least one reading level and 87% were promoted to the next grade. We have administered 11 grants totaling \$2.1M with no audit findings and a 100% on-time reporting rate.	→ Years of operation + specific reach = instant credibility → Outcome percentages prove results, not just effort → Grant history with clean record directly addresses competency and accountability
[THREE-PAGE NARRATIVE — OUTCOME STATEMENT] By June 30, 2026, 85% of the 120 enrolled students will advance at least one reading level as measured by the STAR Reading Assessment administered at program entry and exit. Additionally, 80% will be promoted to the next grade with no academic conditions.	→ Specific date, number served, and percentage target → Names the measurement tool — not just “we will evaluate” → Two distinct outcomes with different measures shows rigor

□ **Team:** Discuss as a group: Which element of this example is your organization currently doing well? Which one needs the most work before your next submission?

Section 3 — Before & After Comparisons

Study each pair. The weak version reflects what most first drafts look like. The strong version shows what a competitive proposal says instead. After each pair, answer the reflection question in the space provided.

Comparison 1 — Internal Clarity: Defining the Problem

□ Weak <i>There is a significant need for job training in our community. Unemployment is high</i>	□ Strong <i>In [Your County], the unemployment rate among adults without a high school diploma</i>
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and many people are struggling to find work. Our program helps people get jobs.

is 3.4 times higher than the county average. Of the 2,200 adults who applied for entry-level positions at our region's top employers last year, 61% were screened out for lacking basic digital literacy skills. Our 16-week workforce readiness program directly addresses this gap.

- What specific techniques did the strong version use that the weak version lacked?

□ **Team discussion:** Where does your organization have data that could make your own problem statement this specific? What data do you still need to find?

Comparison 2 — Proactive vs. Generic Alignment

□ Weak

We are applying for this grant because our organization's work aligns with your foundation's goals. We believe our program would benefit from your support and we hope you will consider our request.

□ Strong

The Hartwell Foundation's 2025 priority to expand economic mobility programs for formerly incarcerated adults maps directly to our Second Chance Employment Initiative, which has placed 143 returning citizens into living-wage employment over the past three years. This request of \$60,000 would fund a fourth cohort serving 40 additional participants.

- What did the writer of the strong version have to know before they could write it? What research did they do?

□ **Team discussion:** Name a specific funder your team is considering. What do you know about their 2024–2025 priorities? What do you still need to find out?

Comparison 3 — Narrative Outcome Statement

□ Weak

□ Strong

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Our program will improve outcomes for participants. We will track attendance and provide support services. At the end of the program, participants will be better prepared for the future.

By December 31, 2025, 75% of the 60 program participants will complete all 12 curriculum modules. Of completers, 80% will secure employment within 90 days of graduation, as tracked through quarterly follow-up surveys and employer verification records.

☐ Write a draft outcome statement for your own program using the strong version as a model. Include: a date, the number of people served, a percentage target, and the measurement tool.

☐ **Team discussion:** Share your draft outcome statements as a group. Are they specific enough? Can you verify them with your current data systems?

Comparison 4 — Sustainability

☐ Weak

We plan to seek additional funding in the future to continue this program. We are committed to our mission and will work hard to ensure our programs continue.

☐ Strong

Beyond this grant period, program sustainability will be secured through three channels: a \$45,000 commitment from the city's community development block grant program (confirmed for FY26), a 15% revenue contribution from program participant fees on a sliding scale, and ongoing cultivation of two additional foundation prospects currently in the relationship-building phase.

☐ List the funding sources your organization would realistically draw on to continue this program after the grant period ends.

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☐ **Team discussion:** *Does your team have an active funder pipeline beyond this grant? Assign someone to map your top three sustainability sources before the next session.*

Section 4 — Your Common Grant Application Builder

Complete each prompt as thoroughly as you can. This is the raw material for your actual proposal. The more specific you are here, the easier the writing will be later. Every section maps directly to a component of the Common Grant Application.

Part A — Cover Letter Elements

☐ Who will you address this letter to? (Name, title, foundation/agency name)

☐ Write your opening hook — a brief story (2–3 sentences) about one person your program served:

☐ **Team discussion:** *Share two or three candidate stories from your organization's work. As a group, choose the one that most clearly shows the impact of your program in human terms.*

☐ The specific dollar amount you are requesting: \$_____

☐ In one sentence, state what that money will fund and why it aligns with this funder's priorities:

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☐ **Tip:** Your cover letter should be one page. It is signed by both your Board Chair and your Executive Director. If you do not yet know who will sign, confirm that before your submission deadline.

Part B — Organization Summary

☐ **Organization name, year founded, and primary service area:**

☐ **Your official mission statement:**

☐ **Who do you serve? (Age, geography, specific population characteristics)**

☐ **How many people did you serve in the most recent program year?**

☐ **What is your strongest evidence of impact? (A specific outcome, percentage, or data point)**

☐ **Grant history: List up to three past grants (funder, amount, year). If you are newer, describe contracts or partnerships that show financial management capacity.**

☐ **Team:** As a team, assign someone to pull your most recent program data and outcome reports before the next session. You cannot write a strong organization summary without current numbers.

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Part C — Three-Page Narrative

☐ The problem your program addresses — stated with current data (include source and year):

☐ Who is affected, how many people, and why has this problem not been solved yet?

☐ Describe your program activities and timeline. What will you do, when, and with whom?

☐ Write at least one measurable outcome using this format: By [date], [%] of [# participants] will [specific result] as measured by [tool].

★Example — Measurable outcome:

By September 30, 2026, 80% of the 45 enrolled participants will complete 90% or more of scheduled program sessions, and 70% will demonstrate a statistically significant reduction in reported stress levels as measured by the PSS-10 scale administered at intake and exit.

☐ Sustainability: How will this program continue after the grant period? Name specific funding sources, revenue strategies, or partners.

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☐ **Team:** Divide the narrative sections among team members for a first draft. Reconvene to ensure the through-line is consistent — every section should tell the same story with reinforcing details.

Part D — Attachments Inventory

Check which documents you currently have ready to attach. For each missing item, note who is responsible and by when.

✓	Document	Responsible	Due By
☐	Most recent audited financials		
☐	Current year operating budget		
☐	Board of directors list		
☐	IRS determination letter (501(c)(3))		
☐	Letters of support from community partners		
☐	Annual report or program summary		
☐	Key staff résumés (if required)		
☐	Organizational chart (if required)		

Section 5 — Module 3 Self-Audit Checklist

Use this checklist to assess where you stand right now. Check every box you can honestly say is true for your organization. Unchecked boxes are your action items before your next submission.

Internal Clarity

- ☐ I can state in two sentences what my organization does, who it serves, and what outcome it produces.
- ☐ I know exactly what program or project I want to seek funding for and why it is a priority right now.
- ☐ I can articulate the specific community problem my program addresses and support it with current data.

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Grant Writing Approach

- ☐ I understand the difference between a proactive proposal and an RFP response, and I approach each differently.
- ☐ When responding to an RFP, I use the funder's language and answer every question they explicitly ask.
- ☐ I have the discipline to decline grant opportunities that do not genuinely align with my mission.

Strategic Planning

- ☐ I track grant deadlines in advance — not just the ones coming up in the next few weeks.
- ☐ I have begun (or plan to begin) building relationships with program officers before submission deadlines.
- ☐ I have a list of funders I am actively cultivating, not just a list of deadlines I am reacting to.

Common Grant Application Readiness

- ☐ COVER LETTER: I have a compelling opening hook ready — a story, a statistic, or a meaningful thank-you.
- ☐ COVER LETTER: I know the specific dollar amount I am requesting and can justify exactly how it will be used.
- ☐ ORG SUMMARY: I have current outcome data (from the most recently completed program year) ready to include.
- ☐ ORG SUMMARY: I can document my grant history and demonstrate a clean track record.
- ☐ NARRATIVE: I have at least one fully written, measurable outcome statement for my proposed program.
- ☐ NARRATIVE: I have a draft sustainability plan identifying at least two funding sources beyond this grant.
- ☐ ATTACHMENTS: I have audited financials, a board list, and my IRS determination letter on file and current.

The Through-Line

- ☐ Every section of my proposal will tell the same story — the numbers, populations, and outcomes will be consistent across the cover letter, narrative, and budget.
- ☐ I have a process for reviewing my final proposal for internal consistency before submission.

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My action items before the next module:

☐ **Team:** As a team, assign each action item an owner and a due date before your next session. Write names next to each item above.

*“Effective grant writing starts with internal clarity,
requires strategic alignment with your funder,
and demands planning well ahead of any deadline.”*

— Grant Writing Masterclass, Module 3